Introduction

Students often ask whether they are required to spell Sanskrit words correctly in their written work. The nice response is that they are expected to show that they understand what the (hopefully recognisable) terms mean. This handbook tries to elucidate the focal meanings of concepts that readers of Indian philosophy in English translations are likely to encounter.

It is in the nature of the case that concepts and logical techniques described here are taken out of specific contexts. I have tried to write in such a way that a glance at a particular entry will assist understanding of the way in which a term is being used on a particular occasion.

The existence of this book testifies to a belief that the study of classical Indian philosophical and religious thought is intrinsically worthwhile. These thinkers were concerned with issues of universal significance that are crystallised and discussed with a singular clarity and argumentative precision. It is to be hoped that this book contributes to an acceptance of the view that it makes sense to speak of World Philosophy, of which classical Indian philosophy is a proper part. No one who has read a closely argued Indian philosophical text can deny that the activity was governed by rigorous canons of rationality and a presumption that conclusions must be justified.

The sociologist Louis Dumont maintained that the key to understanding Indian religion is to be found in the dialogue between the person who has renounced society and the participant in everyday social relations. This is surely an important